

Social work recording: Difficult behaviour

Practice your social work recording skills

Characters:

- Rhonda – Social Worker
- Brian – Service User, 79, sheltered accommodation resident who drinks heavily
- Jenny – Sheltered Accommodation Scheme Manager

Location:

Outside Brian's sheltered accommodation.

Brian, who has been living in his sheltered accommodation flat for three months, is drinking heavily. He can be verbally aggressive to staff and other tenants when drunk. Attempts to limit his drinking have been scuppered by Brian stashing bottles around his flat. Brian has declining cognitive ability; how much (if any) of this is due to his drinking is uncertain. Jenny has called a meeting with Brian and Rhonda, his social worker, to issue a final warning about his tenancy.



SCIE

Case Study: Scenario - Addressing Behaviour

SOUNDCLOUD



[Privacy policy](#)

429

Audio transcript

[SCENE: SHELTERED ACCOMODATION]

[OUTSIDE. IT IS RAINING. RHONDA & JENNY WALK ALONG GRAVEL AS THE TALK.]

Rhonda:

Hello Jenny, sorry I'm a bit late. Got caught in traffic.

Jenny

No problem, thanks for agreeing to this meeting. Horrible weather, isn't it?

Rhonda:

Absolutely foul. I'm already soaked through.

Jenny:

Well, let's hope Brian agrees to let us into the flat. He has been increasingly difficult – as I mentioned on the phone.

Rhonda:

I'm concerned about his capacity to make sound decisions. It was his decision to move into the sheltered accommodation ... just three months ago, and he knew the deal. There was no doubt it was an informed choice on his part at that time.

Jenny:

He's drinking every day. It's really got out of hand,

Rhonda:

Brian has been a heavy drinker all his adult life. He's never been abusive before.

Jenny

It's completely unacceptable the way he talks to the other tenants. He's called me every name under the sun. And he called Fred an fucking bastard.

[NOTE: LEASE RECORD AN ALTERNATIVE OF THE ABOVE LINE REPLACING 'FUCKING BASTARD' WITH 'EFFING BASTARD']

Rhonda:

We'll talk to him today. Hopefully he'll understand the seriousness of the situation.

Jenny:

He's always reasonable when he's sober.... Anyway, ok, here we are...

A DOORBELL.

Jenny:

No answer – what a surprise.

THE DOORBELL RINGS AGAIN. THE SOUND OF THE LETTERBOX BEING OPENED FROM THE OUTSIDE.

Rhonda:

Brian, are you in there? It's Rhonda here – with Jenny, the accommodation manager, you agreed to meet with us today – remember?

Brian:

(from inside his flat) Not taking visitors today. No thank you.

Rhonda:

It's important I get to speak with you, Brian.

Brian:

(from inside; barely audible) I'll speak with you – not with that cow.

Jenny:

What did he say?

Rhonda:

I'm afraid it has to be a meeting with you, me and Jenny.

Brian:

(still inside) Stupid cow, wants to make me homeless. She can get the hell out of here.

Jenny:

Brian, you have to let us in.

Brian:

(still inside) I don't have to let anyone in. This is my home. That was the deal. I chose to live here, I pay for it. This is my home. You're harassing me. Bugger off!

Rhonda:

Brian, I want us all to sit down, see if we can work something out. Jenny wants to give you a final warning.

Brian:

(suddenly up close and very loud) GO AWAY! Do you hear me? Go AWAY! I don't want anything from you!

Jenny:

Have you been drinking, Brian?

Brian:

(still inside) It's none of your business if I choose to drink on a Sunday. Day of rest it is. If I can't have a drink once a week... GO AWAY!

Rhonda:

It's Thursday, Brian. I don't want to have this meeting with you if you've been drinking, but I'm concerned about your welfare.

Jenny:

This has to be his final warning. I've told him he's not allowed to drink if he's going to be abusive to people. We've tried to confiscate alcohol from his flat, but he's hiding them away somewhere...

Brian:

(still inside; muttering) They keep stealing my stuff. Stealing my whiskey. I pay for that from my pension. It shouldn't be allowed (shouting) It should be ME issuing a final warning. I should go to the POLICE. Stealing my booze!

Jenny:

Brian, as you well know, I have a duty of care here... Your drinking is out of control. You're a danger to yourself and you are upsetting all the other tenants.

Brian:

If this is about Audrey she's a lying vindictive piece of... Had it in for me from the start. So what if I've had a drink? Rhonda – tell her... I'm allowed to do what I want. That's what you said about this hell hole. It's still my home.

Jenny:

These are the rules, Brian.

Brian:

There's no way I would have moved here if there was a bleeding alcohol ban. Anyway, Roger at 33 drinks and you don't go around threatening him. You are just a bully, Jenny. You should be in prison.

Jenny:

Roger doesn't shout at the other tenants and make a nuisance of himself.

Brian:

This is all about that time I spoke to the foreman. If there's a problem with the valve it has to be fixed. It's not my fault your husband lost his job.

Jenny:

I think you have me confused with someone else.

Rhonda:

Okay, okay, can I ask you both to listen for a moment. First off, yes – Brian – you're right that it's your choice whether you drink or not...

Jenny:

I really don't think he's making good decisions for himself. I'm simply trying to look after his welfare.

Rhonda:

That may be true and we should try to arrange for Brian to see a doctor for an assessment.

Brian:

(through letterbox) No DOCTORS. Prodding around my private parts.

Rhonda:

But, right now, he is perfectly within his rights to drink excessively if that's his choice.

Jenny:

Really.

Rhonda:

The drinking aside, Brian, you agreed to abide to certain rules when you took on your tenancy agreement here. If you are abusive to other tenants or other staff – no matter what the circumstances, then Jenny is within her rights to issue you with a warning and, if necessary, evict you.

Jenny:

Some of the other tenants have been in tears because of things you've said to them. It's just not acceptable.

Brian:

(through letter box) I'm not moving again. Too much upheaval.

Rhonda:

I understand that Brian, can we talk this through without shouting?

Brian:

I'll talk to you, not that one. Not that one. Got it in for me. It's all about that wretched valve. Should never have got involved...

[TRANSITION TO INDICATE TIME PASSING.]

[BRIAN IS MUCH SOFTER IN HIS ATTITUDE NOW. HE IS MUMBLING THROUGH THE LETTERBOX AND IT IS DIFFICULT TO HEAR ALL HE HAS TO SAY.]

Brian:

Too much disruption, gets me confused. So, I drink a bit... it's a comfort. You understand, don't you, Rhonda?

Rhonda:

I do understand, Brian. But there are rules here – you are allowed to drink, but if you're rude to other people when you've been drinking...

Brian:

(suddenly tearful) I don't want to move! I like it here. I like being part of things here. I can't be kicked out of my home. I don't want to move.

Rhonda:

If you keep being abusive and causing a disruption, you may not have a choice.

Brian:

I don't mean to upset anyone. I'm just lonely sometimes and bored and drink a bit. Get confused. I know I upset Betty the other day. I didn't mean to. I just said the wrong things and it all got out of hand. I apologized to her. It won't happen again.

Jenny:

When you're not drinking, we like you being part of things here too Brian. We really do Brian. You did apologise to Betty and she seems okay with you again – but you've been equally abusive to other tenants and you've not apologised.

Brian:

I forget who I've spoken to. I'll say sorry to everyone if I have to.

Jenny:

What I would prefer is that you stop being aggressive and rude to people.

Brian:

I'll not drink any more today.

Rhonda:

That sounds sensible. Do you think you might let us in, so we can talk things through... ?

Brian:

I don't want visitors. Not today. Not dressed.

Rhonda:

Jenny and I came here today to issue you with a final warning about your tenancy. I want to propose that we withdraw the warning and instead you agree to certain things.

Brian:

Like what? I'm not giving up my whiskey.

Rhonda:

Well, Jenny has said she wants you to stop being aggressive and rude to people. You've said that it isn't your intention to upset anyone and that you're sorry about this. Maybe we could draw up some sort of agreement?

Brian:

She has to stop stealing my booze.

Rhonda:

Well, if you sign a contract that says you won't be aggressive or rude to tenants and staff any more, you will have to stick with it. That might require you to drink less.

Brian:

I don't mind drinking less – she's making out I'm some sort of street alccy... I'm allowed a drink in my own home.

Rhonda:

Jenny – if Brian agrees to a contract of behaviour, are you willing to give him another chance?

Jenny:

Of course, we want Brian to be happy in his home here. But the abuse has got to stop. If he breaks the contract then I'm afraid he's out.

Brian:

Okay, okay! I get it. I'm not losing my marbles just yet you know. I understand. Now, can you leave me in peace?

Rhonda:

Brian, I'm going to spend some time with Jenny now to write up a contract of behaviour for you to sign. If you sign it and keep to it, then you'll be able to continue living here. If you break the contract, then

you'll be given a final warning and then the next course of action is that you'll be asked to leave. Look, none of us want this to happen. Are you clear about what's happening?

Brian:

I get it. Now can I be left alone? I'll just stay inside today, that way I can't upset anyone can I?

Rhonda:

I'll come back next week, Thursday at 10am, and we can go through all this again.

Brian:

On your own?

Rhonda:

On my own.

Brian:

Okay, okay. Fine.

Jenny:

Thanks , Brian.

[END OF SCENARIO.]

(Next week Rhonda returns, but Brian is not there. What would you (Mr/Ms Elearner) do now?)

How would you record the events?

Reveal model answer

08.09.17 – Joint Visit to Brian's flat with Jenny Harris, Housing Officer. Brian had been informed of the appointment by letter.



The purpose of the visit to discuss concerns Jenny had about Brian's behaviour. Jenny reported that Brian was being verbally aggressive to other tenants and inappropriate in the language he used. She felt this was due to his heavy drinking. She reported that she had tried to work with him to limit his drinking but this had been scuppered by him stashing bottles around his flat. She also felt that Brian has declining cognitive ability and feels that this is due to his drinking.

Although I arrived 10 minutes later than arranged Jenny had waited for me before approaching Brian's flat. On ringing the doorbell we initially got no response but on ringing the bell again and speaking through the letter box Brian answered but refused to let us in. I explained who we were and why we were there. Brian said that he would speak with me but not 'with that cow' referring to Jenny.

I again explained to Brian that it was important that we come in and have a discussion as Jenny wanted to give him a final warning and I wanted to see if we could find a way to resolve the difficulties he was having with his tenancy. Brian shouted "go away" and "bugger off" through the letter box.

When I asked Brian if he had been drinking he said that it was "none of your business". During the conversation, he appeared confused and disorientated. He said that he thought it was Sunday. He also got Jenny confused with someone else and referred to her as a "cow" twice. (Accurate) (Real)

I explained to Jenny that:

- It was Brian's choice as to how much he drank
- Brian had been drinking all his adult life
- Brian had not had a history of abusive remarks/behaviour before and that this may indicate a deterioration in his condition.

I explained to Brian that:

- There were rules related to the tenancy that he had agreed to
- That Jenny could issue a final warning if he broke the rules
- The situation was serious and if he wanted to remain in this tenancy then he had to work with us

Jenny stated that Brian:

- Had agreed to the conditions of the tenancy.

- Could not continue to upset the other tenants and if he did she would issue a final warning which would lead to him having to move out if his behaviour continued.
- She also confirmed that she had confiscated alcohol from his flat

Brian stated that:

- He was upset that whiskey he had bought was being removed from his flat and he viewed this as stealing
- He did not want to move and got upset at the prospect.
- He did not want to upset anybody and he had apologised (Succinct)

After 45 mins of discussion through the letter box I tried to move the discussion forward in a way that was agreeable to all.

I suggested to Brian that we draw up a contract of behaviour. Jenny agreed that if Brian agreed to this and was able to stick to the contract then he would be able to remain in his flat. Brian agreed to this.

Brian, Jenny and I agreed the following actions:

1. Jenny would not issue the final warning today
2. Jenny and I would draw up a behaviour contract with clear statements about what is not acceptable behaviour.
3. I would visit again tomorrow on my own and go through the contract with Brian and ask him to agree and sign it.
4. Signed copies would be kept on housing and social care files and Brian would have his own copy
5. Brian would try to drink less

I will also discuss Brian's condition with the Drug and Alcohol team and see if they think it would be helpful to re-engage with Brian to support him in his wish, expressed today, to drink less. I will also ask them for a professional opinion as to whether Brian's cognitive abilities were now being affected and how this would affect future care planning.

The interview today was not ideal as we were not able to enter Brian's flat. The situation was so serious however that I felt I needed to persevere. I also felt that Brian had been drinking today and this affected my ability to have a full discussion with him in which he could fully engage. I did feel however that there

were moments when he was able to have a good insight on the impact of his behaviour and the gravity of the situation. I felt that the discussions today provided a starting point for more detailed discussions with Brian tomorrow and Jenny today so that both parties felt supported. I will also be able to undertake a more detailed assessment of Brian's mental capacity. (Holistic) (Person centred)

Jenny had mentioned during the discussions today that Brian had joined in with activities and everybody enjoyed him being part of activities in the complex. I will ask Jenny if she can try to maximise this more positive aspect of Brian's behaviour as this may improve his relationships with other tenants and improve his quality of life. If appropriate I will see if I can formalise this in the behaviour contract. (Holistic) (Person centred)



social care
institute for excellence

Charity No. 1092778
Company Reg. No. 4289790
SCIE, Isosceles Head Office
One High Street
Egham TW20 9HJ
Tel: [0203 8404040](tel:02038404040)
Email: info@scie.org.uk

© Social Care Institute for Excellence.
All rights reserved

[Cookies](#) [Privacy](#) [Terms of use](#) Website by [Itineris](#)

You and SCIE

[Make an enquiry](#)

[Login into MySCIE](#)

[Register for
MySCIE](#)

[My e-learning](#)

[My checkout
basket](#)

About SCIE

[About us](#)

[Support our work](#)

[Consultancy](#)

[Training and e-
learning](#)

[Modern slavery
and human
trafficking
statement](#)

Resources

[Safeguarding](#)

[Mental capacity](#)

[Care Act](#)

[Social work](#)

[LGBTQ+ adult
care](#)

Follow us

